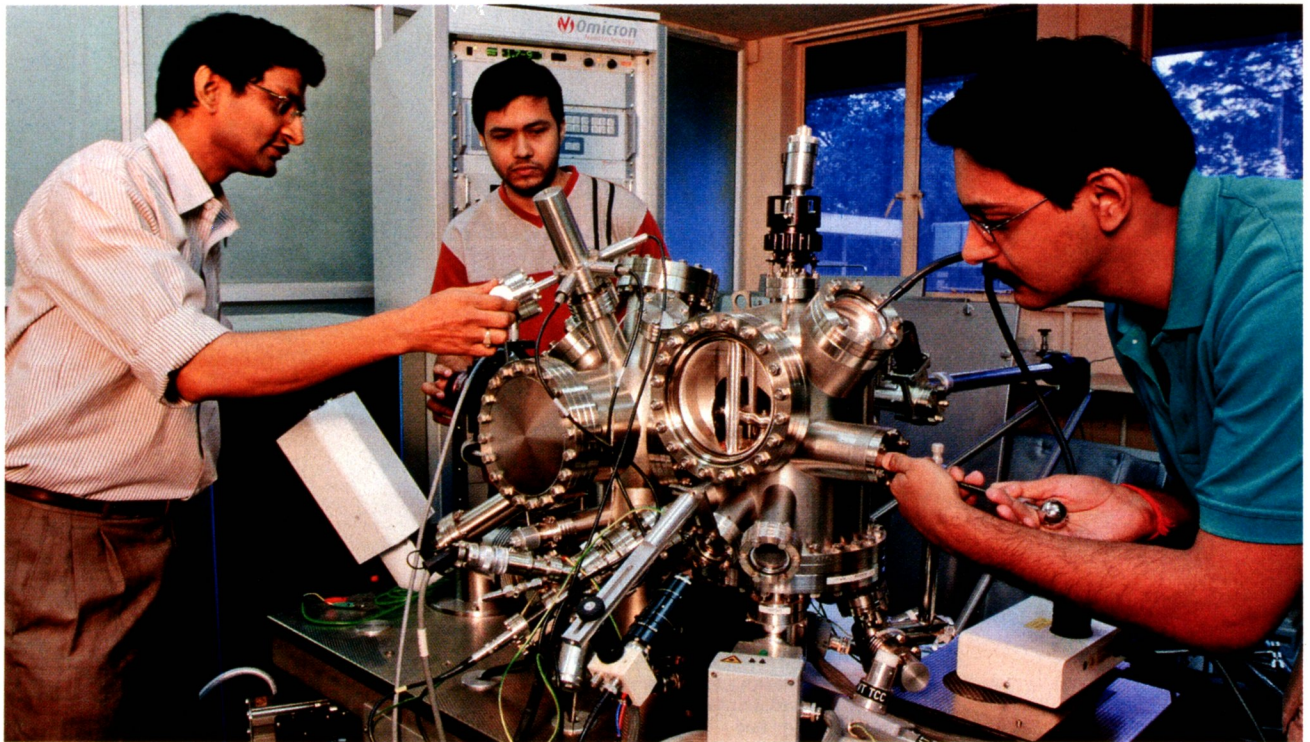


GREAT IDEAS GREAT MINDS

Dipankar Gupta

Quality, and not quantity, should be the **FOCUS IN SCIENCE EDUCATION.** No investment in R&D means no real progress.



SUVASHIS MULLICK

If there is one big idea that India should pursue then that is of making this country a knowledge powerhouse. We started off on the right note, but lost our way subsequently. We spend almost nothing on research and development (R&D) and do not even feel the need to buck up on this score. In fact, our R&D expenditure has gone down. Between 1990 and 1998, the total money devoted by the state to R&D fell from Rs 219 crore to Rs 156 crore, which is shocking especially as India had begun it on a positive note after Independence. In 1947, the founding fathers of our national movement came up with a Constitution so remarkable that democratic countries world over sat up and took notice. The first genera-

tion of leaders of Independent India did not want just political sovereignty but economic and intellectual sovereignty as well. This is the big idea we should relentlessly pursue today. India should fight back and claim intellectual sovereignty by pushing the frontiers of knowledge. We set up several IITs, we have over 270 universities and famous institute of sciences, but we have forgotten to energise them with funds and enthuse them to do research.

All our ideas about modern knowledge come primarily from the West, and often do not suit our demands. We have millions who are sick and ailing, but we are yet to conduct appropriate research that could help them. Even in the much-vaunted information technology, we are adept at doing pretty primitive

Unusual sight: Even the best universities in India do not favour research